



contemporary receptacles. In most parts of India, the sight of dhoti-clad workers dodging traffic and skipping over potholes clutching their precious tiffin boxes is as common as it is comical. Yet, nowhere is it more a part of the city landscape than in Mumbai, where the famous *dabbawallahs* ferry millions of them across the city, come rain or shine, with such precise timing and efficiency that it is now the subject of a Harvard study. T is also for **Tendulkar**, the little big man whose performance on a given day can rattle the Sensex and cause a million argumentative Indians to go into a collective frenzy of analysis and debate, even depression.



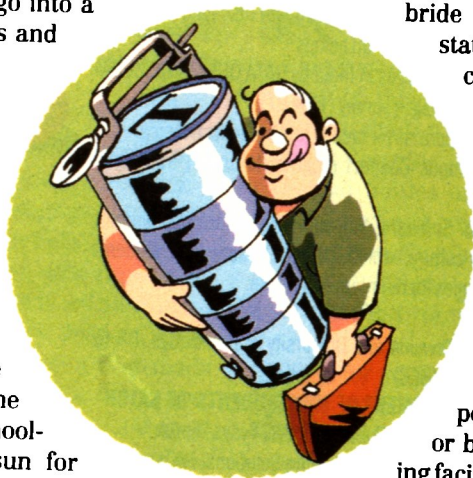
for **Unpunctuality**, another annoying but common Indian habit. Why Indians wear watches is anybody's guess since they can never arrive anywhere in time. Official functions start well after the appointed hour because some VIP woke up late and left school-children standing in the sun for hours; appointments and meetings are shifted and rescheduled with gay abandon; and in keeping with that trend, even trains arrive and depart well past their scheduled time. Easily the most common symptom of this contagious disease is dinners or cocktails. Arriving late for a party is a sign that you have a busy social life, even if you have come straight from your own house. To arrive on time is to commit the gravest of social sins, leading to immediate elimination from invitation lists.



for **Vedic**, the ancient Hindu philosophy that still governs the lives of millions of Indians. The Vedas are an integral part of all religious or auspicious functions, carrying a religious sanctity that overrides any piece of official paper. V is also for **Verification**, a process inherited from the British and still extant, wherein your entire life, from birth to death, is spent explaining who you are, where you were born, what caste you are, what is your father's name, your occupation, residence, family and marital status and innumerable other minor and meaningless details that officious policemen and clerks will then spend their entire lives verifying. V also stands for **Virgin**, a physical condition that is so coveted and desirable, especially before marriage, that newspaper matrimonials frequently feature the phrase "virgin widow".



for **Wedding**, that great Indian tamasha that cannot be matched for scale, size, extravagance and expenditure anywhere else in the world. Lasting for days, sometimes an entire week, Indian weddings have become a bizarre mix of social statement, financial worth, one-upmanship and showmanship, where the real purpose of the occasion, the marriage of a young couple, somehow recedes into the background and the solemn marriage vows are drowned in the din of the bhangra beat. The ultimate irony: instead of gifts for the bride and groom, the ultimate status symbol is the gift that comes along with the gold-leafed wedding invitation. For Indians, inveterate status-seekers, marriages are truly heaven-sent.



for **Xerox Centre**, as ubiquitous as PCOS and ATMS. 'Xerox centre' also happens to be a nomenclature peculiar to India. Every shop or booth that offers photocopying facilities calls itself a 'Xerox centre', even though Xerox is a registered brand name and the photocopying machine being used could be of an entirely different make. Though Xerox is now universally used as a term to mean a copy, Xerox centres are not, except in India.



stands for **Yoga**, that ancient Indian practice that combines spirituality, discipline and good health, among other desirables. In recent years, it has gone global with a vengeance and in India made a remarkable comeback, with yoga classes and television channels growing in number and popularity. It has made superstars of yoga teachers like Baba Ramdev while other experts have acquired celebrity status in the West. It's all a question of positioning.



for **Zero**, the number invented by an Indian mathematician, and it also stands for **Zero Tolerance**, something increasingly witnessed among Indians, especially in the cases of road rage reported almost every day. Zero tolerance is also increasingly to do with the Indian voter, who keeps dumping one government for another (except in the two Communist states), with little to show for his/her efforts except rickety coalitions, which is where this article, appropriately, began.